

MIG-3

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-3

Age: 41

Gender: Female

Country of origin: India

Host country: Canada

Years in host country: 9

Occupation: Software Engineer

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I immigrated to Canada nine years ago through the skilled worker points-based programme. In India I already had a good and stable job in technology, so this was not a move driven by desperation, but the opportunities in the tech sector here were of a different order altogether, and I wanted my daughter to grow up in a society that felt more egalitarian, with more room for women to advance on their own merits. Canada's international reputation for multiculturalism and its relatively welcoming immigration policy drew me in. I researched extensively before deciding, prepared for the transition carefully, and arrived with qualifications and some savings, which made my landing far softer than that of many other migrants, a privilege I am very conscious of.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means that my ideas are genuinely valued in meetings regardless of my accent or the way I phrase things, and that I can rise into leadership positions without hitting an invisible ceiling that quietly holds people like me back. It means that my culture is actively celebrated during festivals like Diwali in the office, not merely tolerated as an exotic curiosity or ignored altogether. True inclusion, as I have come to understand it, is when difference itself becomes recognised as a source of strength and fresh perspective rather than something to be smoothed away or assimilated into invisibility. It is being able to bring my whole self to work and to public life without having to perform a version of myself that makes others more comfortable.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: I have faced subtle xenophobia far more often than overt hostility. People frequently assume I must be in a junior technical role rather than a senior one, or they ask where I am 'really' from even after I mention that I am a Canadian citizen, as though citizenship were something that could not quite apply to someone who looks like me. On one memorable occasion a client requested a 'local' engineer instead of me, and the implication was unmistakable. These microaggressions are rarely dramatic enough to point to individually, but they accumulate steadily over the years and serve as a constant, quiet reminder that some people still see me as an outsider, a guest rather than a full member of the society I

have committed my life and my family's future to.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: Surprisingly, my main challenge was not the language, since I spoke English well before arriving, but rather the professional and social culture. In India the workplace is more hierarchical and communication tends to be more indirect and deferential, whereas here a certain amount of self-promotion and assertive networking is not only accepted but actively expected of anyone who wants to advance. Learning to advocate for myself, to speak up about my accomplishments without feeling that I was being immodest, took me several years and did not come naturally. The famously harsh Canadian winters were also a genuine shock to my system that I never fully adjusted to, and the sheer distance from my extended family in India weighed on me constantly.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: The Canadian tech industry is reasonably diverse, particularly at the more junior levels, and my current company genuinely values inclusion and has backed that value with concrete mentorship and advancement for me. My managers have actively guided me toward promotions and championed my work. That said, I have noticed clearly that the higher one climbs, the whiter and more male the rooms tend to become. I am frequently the only South Asian woman at the executive table, which can feel isolating and which places a certain unspoken pressure on me to represent more than just myself. Still, on balance my professional experience has been positive, and I try to hold the door open behind me for others.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I have balanced both cultures very deliberately and thoughtfully. My daughter attends Bharatanatyam dance classes and speaks Hindi at home with me, so that she remains connected to her heritage, but she is also a proud Canadian who plays ice hockey and moves through Canadian life with complete ease. For my own part, I have adopted Canadian values that I genuinely admire, such as politeness, environmental consciousness, and a certain social openness, while keeping intact our family's spiritual traditions, our festivals, and the closeness and mutual obligation that characterise Indian family life. It is a rich and deliberate blend rather than a replacement of one identity by another, and I consider the ability to draw on two cultures a genuine gift rather than a burden.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: Media representation of Indians has improved somewhat in recent years but it remains stubbornly stereotypical, often reducing us to tech workers, taxi drivers, or convenience store owners, and rarely presenting complex, fully realised Indian-Canadian characters with inner lives and ordinary Canadian concerns. This kind of representation matters far more than people tend to assume, because positive and varied visibility shapes whether my daughter grows up feeling that she genuinely belongs in the national story of this country or that she is forever a footnote to it. When children see people who look like them portrayed only in narrow roles, it subtly limits how they imagine their own possibilities and how others imagine them.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: The settlement services I used when I first arrived were genuinely excellent, offering resume workshops tailored to the Canadian job market, networking events for newcomers, and practical guidance on everything from banking to housing. They eased my transition significantly and I am grateful for them. Canada, in my observation, invests more seriously in newcomer integration than many other countries do, and it shows. That said, these resources are heavily concentrated in the major urban centres, and newcomers who settle in smaller towns or rural areas often find themselves without any comparable support. Urban immigrants like me are, in that respect, considerably more fortunate than those who land somewhere with fewer services and smaller established communities.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My daughter is thriving and feels fully and unquestionably Canadian, which fills me with joy but occasionally with a quiet sadness as well, because she is inevitably less connected to India than I had once hoped she would be. She experiences racism at school sometimes, casual cruelty from other children, which breaks my heart every time she tells me about it. Yet she is confident, self-possessed, and genuinely proud of her heritage, which I work carefully to nurture without ever forcing it upon her. She represents, to me, a new kind of Canadian who can hold two worlds comfortably, and I hope her generation will face fewer of the questions about belonging that still follow mine.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, I believe we must move well beyond token diversity celebrations, the occasional cultural food day, toward real and measurable structural change in how people are hired, retained and promoted. Anti-racism education certainly helps, but so does economic security more broadly: when people feel financially safe and unthreatened, they are far less likely to fear newcomers as competitors for scarce resources. In my own experience, sustained contact and shared goals dissolve prejudice more effectively than anything else, when people work side by side toward something they both care about, the abstract fear of the other tends to give way to the concrete reality of a colleague and, often, a friend.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I aspire to reach a senior leadership position in my field and, from that vantage point, to open doors for other immigrant women in technology who face the same subtle barriers I encountered. I already mentor several younger newcomers, and I find that work deeply meaningful. Looking further ahead, I would love to build a foundation supporting girls' education in the STEM fields, both here in Canada and back in India, as a way of giving something concrete back to both of the countries that have shaped who I am. Personally, I simply hope to see my daughter grow into a confident, grounded adult who never has to question whether she belongs.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to newcomers is to invest real effort in understanding the unspoken professional culture, the norms around self-promotion, networking, and communication, and not just the language itself, because fluency alone does not guarantee that you will be understood or advanced. Network relentlessly and without embarrassment, because relationships open the majority of doors here. Do not shrink yourself or dim your perspective in an effort to fit in; your distinct viewpoint, shaped by your

background, is a genuine professional asset. And above all, find a mentor who believes in you and is willing to champion your growth, because a good advocate can change the entire trajectory of your career.